

body that would, in time, evolve into the European Commission. Membership of this European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) would be open to all other western European countries, and the HA would be composed of government-appointed representatives of each member state.

It was hoped that, in due course, greater political integration would follow. "Europe will not be made all at once," Schuman declared. "It will be built through concrete achievements which first create a de facto solidarity. The coming together of the nations of Europe requires the elimination of the age-old opposition of France and Germany." The pooling of coal and steel industries would mean that "any war between France and Germany becomes not merely unthinkable but materially impossible." It would be the "first concrete foundation of a European federation, indispensable to the preservation of peace."

German chancellor Konrad Adenauer was enthusiastic, as were the leaders of Italy and the Benelux countries, though the UK demurred. Importantly, the idea also had the backing of US secretary of

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Common foundations
for economic development ...
will change the destinies
of those regions which
have long been devoted
to the manufacture
of munitions of war.

Robert Schuman
The Schuman Declaration, 1950

state George C. Marshall, whose Marshall Plan, enacted in 1948, poured billions of American dollars into postwar Europe to rebuild infrastructure and foster trade.

The Treaty of Paris

In June 1950, delegates from France, West Germany, Italy, and the Benelux countries began the negotiations that would lead to the creation of the ECSC. The Treaty of Paris was finally signed

in April 1951 and came into force in July 1952. The talks were complex. Not all parties shared the same vision as Monnet, and hopes of an overarching political union were quickly dashed.

Monnet was sure that the HA was the key to integration: countries could appeal to the HA to review any decision they did not like. But for the Benelux countries, this was not enough, and as a democratic safeguard to stop the HA from taking dictatorial control, they proposed a Special Council of Ministers. This would be made up of representatives of each national government, and it could challenge the HA's decisions or hear appeals itself. More significantly, some delegates also proposed a Court of Justice, believing that a strong court could help build the constitutional system that Europe would need in order to achieve full integration.

Monnet was skeptical about the proposed court, believing that it would impede cooperation. But both ideas—of the Special Council of Ministers and of a Court of Justice—had support. The Benelux delegates wanted the court to be



Jean Monnet

French political adviser Jean Monnet was a pioneer of European integration and the brains behind the Schuman Plan, which merged western European heavy industry to form the European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC).

Born in 1888 in the Cognac region, the young Monnet traveled the world for the family cognac business and became a respected international financier. During World War I, he gained distinction as an economic intermediary between France and its allies,

and in 1919, he was made deputy secretary general of the League of Nations. In 1952, he became the first president of the ECSC.

Monnet worked tirelessly toward realizing his dream of a fully integrated European community. In 1955, he set up the Action Committee for the United States of Europe, which was a driving force behind subsequent achievements, such as the creation of the Common Market and, ultimately, the European Union. Monnet died in 1979.